
Evaluation of the Share Our Story (#SOS) project

20
DEGREES
EVALUATION



Cynllun Grantiau Cymru ac Affrica Llywodraeth Cymru



Welsh Government's Wales and Africa Grant Scheme

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The authors have tended to use the language of the social model of disability i.e. rather than talk of people's disabilities, they have referred to people's impairments or conditions, acknowledging that it is within the gift of society to enable or disable people.

Glossary

DWA	Disability in Wales and Africa
OPD	Organisation of Persons with Disabilities
PWD	Persons with Disabilities
WCVA	Wales Council for Voluntary Action

Executive Summary

A light touch evaluation was conducted by 20 Degrees Consulting Ltd, in keeping with the scale of the project. A mixed method research approach was used, drawing on interviews, a survey and management information.

The project largely achieved its outcomes i.e. establishment of a safe place online where disabled people from across Africa and Wales could share their lived experiences for the benefit of other disabled people.

Participation grew from four African countries plus Wales at the start of the project to 10 African countries plus Wales by the end. The findings indicated motivation to become participants typically stemmed from a desire to learn from the lived experiences of other disabled people.

There was a high degree of participant engagement within the group, reinforcing a series of findings that the #SOS group was a safe place for disabled people.

There were high rates of respondents reporting improved understanding of themselves and others through participation in the project. Experiences as disabled people transcended national and impairment / condition boundaries. This translated into a desire amongst participants to create change, either for themselves or others. Further, the findings suggested participants felt more empowered through their learning. The desire for change had translated into actual change reported by 62% of survey respondents.

A key objective was to generate a database of stories to support the continued education of disabled people across Wales and Africa. It was envisaged the stories would be used as tools in advocating for inclusive development. While not a formal project target agreed with the funder, DWA had set a target internally of 150 stories shared between project participants. This was exceeded by 10%.

Topics of discussion were defined by disabled people, reflecting their lived experience. Sub-groups formed around specific demographic groups.

The findings indicated significant learning by participants, both at a personal level and identified examples of translation of that learning into Organisations of Persons with Disabilities (OPDs).

The findings identified project legacy, again at the individual and organisational levels. Continuation of the #SOS group, at least in the short term, was likely to be part of the project legacy.

Output attainment presented a more mixed picture. The headline target of number of participants was not met in Africa nor Wales. This fed through to under-achievement relative to targets in volunteering, education and skills outputs through direct participation. Potentially, indirect learning through cascade training into OPDs may have led to achievement of participation targets. However, this could not be quantified within the limits of this evaluation.

Lessons learned from the project led to four recommendations for DWA. Two focussed on project legacy, encouraging DWA to identify funding to employ a part-time Africa Coordinator, if possible, and to make proactive use of the stories collected through the project. The other two recommendations related to the need for DWA to build capacity and give greater priority to the Wales side of its future projects, if it is to be of greatest benefit to the inclusive development agenda.

1. Introduction

The Share Our Story project was scheduled to run between 1st January and 31st December 2023 with the support of Welsh Government's Wales and Africa Grant Scheme, managed by WCVA. An extension to 30th June 2024 was agreed in February 2024. Table 1.1 summarises the funding for the project.

Table 1.1 – Summary of project funding

Funding source	Contribution (£)
Welsh Government	15,484
Susila Dharma Britain	750
DWA time volunteered	11,076
Total	27,310

The project developed from the Tell Your Story (TYS) pilot project, supported by Susila Dharma Britain in 2021.

According to the project application, the project aimed:

1. To empower deaf and disabled communities from Wales and Africa by bringing them together to share their ideas, experiences, and expertise (their stories), thus promoting their inclusion through a greater knowledge of what has been achieved elsewhere.
2. To develop a database of stories from deaf and disabled people to be used to promote disability inclusive development.

The primary means of enabling people to share their stories was envisaged as WhatsApp, albeit DWA was open to expanding to other social media channels according to the wishes of the participants. It was anticipated Zoom would be used to bring together people simultaneously in events or educational sessions.

2. Methodology

The project was relatively small, with a cash budget of £16,234. The external evaluation therefore needed to be relatively light touch in order to achieve a realistic cost of c.5% of the available budget. With this in mind, the following was undertaken:

- Review of the project application and project profile to understand what the project proposed to achieve and how
- A group interview via Zoom with two members of the DWA committee and the African Coordinator. DWA committee members were in Wales while the project coordinator was in Kenya.
- A survey of project participants.
- Individual interviews with a sample of participants in the project drawn from Africa and Wales.

A survey invitation to users of the WhatsApp group was circulated to participants on three occasions over the course of a month. The survey questions were based upon a basic research framework drafted by an academic at Swansea University – [annex A](#). This individual intended to undertake the evaluation of #SOS but needed to withdraw due to capacity issues. The evaluator decided to recognise the contribution of the academic by including their approach as part of the methodology used.

Table 2.1 – Summary of primary research

Research method	Number of participants (percentage of those approached)	Comment
Group interview	3 (100%)	
Individual participant interviews	7 (70%)	7 African and 3 Welsh participants were approached for interview – 5 African and 2 Welsh respondents
Participant survey	34 (54%)	There were 63 active members of the WhatsApp group

Comparison of the countries of survey respondents with the breakdown of overall WhatsApp group participants suggested the survey responses were likely to be broadly representative¹. Respondents exhibited a wide range of impairments and

¹ A breakdown of WhatsApp users is provided in table 3.1 and survey respondents in the response to question 2 in annex C. Ghanaian responses were the only group notably under-represented in survey responses.

conditions². A larger percentage of males was apparent in the respondents than might have been expected from the general population split in gender³. This represented a potential bias in the survey responses, albeit the gender breakdown of total #SOS participants was unknown.

The interview sample was purposive i.e. the sample was suggested by the African Coordinator based on being known contributors to the WhatsApp group. The sample contained people with a range of impairments / conditions and the seven people in the sample from Africa were drawn from six countries, to obtain a range of backgrounds and experiences.

Example interview topic guides can be found at [annex B](#) and the survey responses can be found at [annex C](#).

In retrospect, the timing of the research phase of the evaluation was unfortunate. It was undertaken in February 2024, largely. This was prior to the project extension being granted.

² Responses to question 11, annex C

³ Responses to question 10, annex C

3. Findings

3.1 Governance and management

The project funding was managed by DWA, with oversight by the DWA Management Group. The African Coordinator was employed by the Meru North Disability Community Centre, the Kenyan partner for the project. Employment of the African Coordinator transferred to DWA during the period of project extension.

3.2 Promotion of the project

Word of mouth appeared to play the biggest role in attracting participants to the project. The African Coordinator, based in Kenya, was an alumna of Bridge Kenya, a training initiative to support organisations of persons with disabilities and disability rights advocates to develop an inclusive and comprehensive perspective on development, including the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD)⁴. This gave her a network of disabled activists from a range of African countries to whom #SOS could be promoted.

Despite these initial contacts providing names of key contacts in disabled people's organisations, there were still hurdles to overcome:

"The biggest hurdle I faced was, okay, of course I had contacts of people who linked me to different organisations of persons with disabilities in their country, but these people, they never knew me. So, you know, with the world today, the cybercrimes, all those other things [...] So, at the beginning I faced that mistrust from the different organisations that I tried to reach."

African Coordinator

Nevertheless, the African Coordinator was able to convince these people that she represented a genuine project. Where the African Coordinator lacked initial contacts, the networks of members of DWA were leveraged, for example in finding a contact in the Central African Republic. Interview findings also identified examples of #SOS participants being introduced to the group by members of the DWA management group.

There were 33 participants in the #SOS WhatsApp thread at the start of the project due to participation in the pilot project funded by Susila Dharma Britain. These participants were drawn from the following five countries:

⁴ Further information can be found at United Disabled Persons of Kenya (2021) Bridge CRPD-SDGs Kenya – Module 1. Available at <https://www.udpkenya.or.ke/blog/bridge-crpdsdgs-kenya-module-1/>. Accessed 4th April 2024

- Ghana
- Kenya
- Nigeria
- Uganda
- Wales.

By the end of the project, there were 63 active participants (growth of 91%), but due to various people joining and leaving during the course of the year there had been engagement by 74 people drawn from 11 countries, as summarised in table 3.1. Countries where there was participation at the outset are in **bold**.

Table 3.1 –Participation in #SOS WhatsApp thread during the project lifetime

Country	Number of participants	Percentage of participants
Kenya	24	32.4%
Wales	13	17.6%
South Africa	11	14.9%
Ghana	7	9.5%
Tanzania	6	8.1%
Zambia	6	8.1%
Uganda	2	2.7%
Zimbabwe	2	2.7%
Lesotho	1	1.4%
Nigeria	1	1.4%
Central African Republic	1	1.4%

Percentages do not sum to 100% due to rounding error

While leveraging networks of individuals appeared to be the most effective means of promotion, social media was used also. This primarily took place via the #SOS Facebook site⁵ but was also supported using the DWA Facebook site⁶. Although the #SOS Facebook site only had 26 followers, seven⁷ of those liking the site were organisations and may have cascaded posts to members.

⁵ The #SOS Facebook site was started on 16th February 2023 and was accessible at <https://www.facebook.com/profile.php?id=100089873220193>. Accessed 6th April 2024

⁶ The DWA Facebook site was available at <https://www.facebook.com/DWANetwork>. Accessed 6th April 2024

⁷ The seven organisations were a mix of African and Welsh organisations: Ghana Deaf News, Ghana Disability Network, InAble, Inclusion Ghana, Learning Disability Wales, Lesotho National Association of the Physically Disabled and NUDIPU - Uganda

The original project application suggested a short-term (less than a year) Social Media and Communication Officer would be hosted by DWA, This had not taken place by the time of the evaluation, but was envisaged for June 2024.

Motivation for joining as a #SOS participant largely centred on wanting to learn from the lived experience of other disabled people, perhaps with different impairments / conditions.

“As a person with lived experience of disability [...], I was interested in the stories of other persons with disability in Africa and Wales. I also felt that my own stories will be useful for making comparisons as we all work together to advise and strengthen each other.”

#SOS participant

“I was curious to know whether other disabled people like me experience life's challenges in the same way as I have faced. Or if African way of treatment to disabled persons is different from that of European countries.”

#SOS participant

3.3 Activities

The project coordinator played a key role in starting and moderating discussions within the WhatsApp group. She also coordinated the various education events (see [3.4](#)).

Topics of conversations within the group were varied but tended to fall into the following broad categories:

- Education
- Health and rehabilitation
- Marriage and relationships
- Adolescent transition
- Trauma
- Employment and income generation (including economic empowerment)
- Religion and healing
- Inclusive communication
- Transport
- Media
- Role of organisations for persons with disabilities (OPD) / disabled people's organisations (DPO).

Some 165 stories had been shared by the end of the project, in increase on the 150 that the project team had hoped would be shared.

Each of these topics tended to be discussed from the perspective of the challenges faced by disabled people i.e. it was based on the lived experience of participants. Taking education as an example, the perspective was generally one of access challenges. These varied depending on the conditions of participants. Blind people might need a guide to overcome access to transport and education, whereas wheelchair users might face physical barriers to accessing education and transport. For example, some African participants were interested to hear that efforts were made to make train access possible in Wales.

Case study 3.1 – A universal story

A participant in #SOS shared:

“There was a story that was shared about caregivers taking advantage of people with disabilities, or children with disabilities, like NGOs, like schools or government institutions, and of course, and even caring centres. So, people contributed, and it is something that could be seen cutting across, both in Africa and Wales. When people learned that this is something that can happen in either of the countries, for most people, it was a great learning for them.

Case study 3.1 illustrated a theme amongst participants that being a disabled person gave rise to a common bond between people, regardless of nationality or impairment / condition.

“The discussion that I found most interesting is the one that some members shared about their personal experiences. It was helpful to me, as I came to realise that all disabled persons' misfortunes are similar.”

#SOS participant

Over time the group evolved from sharing stories only to sharing practical help. An example was a group of artists in Tanzania (Albino Revolution Cultural Troupe) linking with a group of artists in Wales (Disability Arts Cymru) to share experiences and learning.

The funding application for the project envisaged establishment of three sub-discussion groups. This was anticipated in thematic topics, such as Deaf people's lives, livelihood & income, and effective advocacy. In practice, participants took the development in a slightly different direction, with the following sub-groups formed:

- A Swahili group – five members
- A young persons' group – 10 members.

The Swahili group emerged for those that did not speak English. The young person's group emerged from a review of progress by the project team.

"We realised that the SOS was comprised of mostly the veteran disability rights advocates. So, we had so many people past 40 years, so the young people never had a safe space."

Member of the #SOS team

There was also discussion about a French-speaking sub-group forming but that had not emerged at the time of the evaluation.

3.4 Education

There were five educational events open to participants from African countries and Wales.

- Introductory general meeting
- International Women's Day – 8th March
- Introduction to Master Storytelling through Hub Cymru Africa – 11th October
- General meeting to prepare for the International Day of Persons with Disabilities
- International Day of Persons with Disabilities – 3rd December

The two general meetings were included in the list of educational events because attendees shared their lived experiences at these meetings, giving participants insights into the situations and legal frameworks prevalent in other countries.

Elements of these events were shared online through DWA's social media accounts. One example is reproduced as case study 3.2.

Case study 3.2 – International Women's Day

An interview was held with Melanie Lubbe, South African Disability Alliance as part of the International Women's Day event:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OXjFv94MFRs> – 9 minutes - 34 views⁸

⁸ Number of views on 6th April 2024

Beyond these formal educational opportunities, the African Coordinator was able to identify general informal learning that took place through the events. Typically, participants were unused to online video conferencing platforms, such as Zoom, but were coached in their use by the Coordinator.

"We've had most of our members who we are not conversant with the online meetings platform. They are now conversant because sometimes during the meeting I would literally go to people's inboxes to just give them steps on how they can be able to join the Zoom, how they can be able to contribute to the Zoom."

African Coordinator

3.5 Volunteering

Volunteering was a key feature of events. Although all events were online, sometimes groups participated while meeting together. Consequently, the types of volunteering that took place included the following examples:

- developing Powerpoint presentations
- acting as sign language interpreters
- tactile interpretation for deaf-blind participants
- acting as guides to take blind people to meetings
- aides to push wheelchair users to enable meeting attendance.

4. Outputs, outcomes and legacy

4.1 Outputs

Progress made towards target outputs for the project are detailed in Table 4.1, compiled from the #SOS project monitoring system. Progress was RAG rated according to the following key:

Green – Target achieved or exceeded

Amber – Target not achieved but the output exceeded 85% of target

Red – The output was less than 85 % of target

Table 4.1 – Progress towards target outputs

Target description	Target number	Number achieved	Comment
Communities engaged in Africa to support the improvement in their wellbeing	10	10	
Individuals directly engaged to support their wellbeing	150	80	
Links between communities in Wales and Africa established	10	10	Links were between disabled people in Wales with disabled people in 10 African countries
Welsh volunteers involved in project activities	30	12	
African volunteers involved in project activity	150	80	
Number of people in Wales engaged/supported by the project	30	12	
People from Welsh communities supporting the project through donations, events attended etc	25	15	
Organisations strengthened or empowered because of partnership working	13	21	Organisations listed in annex D
Events/sessions delivered in Wales	5	5	
Events/sessions delivered in Africa	5	5	

Wales and African communities linked	10	10	
African children/adults supported with their educational needs	100	63	This was the number of people in Africa directly involved in the #SOS project. The #SOS team made the case that these people tended to be involved in disabled people's organisations and cascaded their learning within these organisations. On that basis, the number of people indirectly educated may have resulted in the target having been met.
People in Wales supported to improve their skills	15	6	
People in Africa supported to improve their skills	100	53 ^{**}	This was the number of instances of people in Africa attending #SOS events. The #SOS team made the case that these people tended to be involved in disabled persons organisations and cascaded their learning within these organisations. On that basis, the number of people indirectly learning skills may have resulted in the target having been met.

Source: #SOS project monitoring system

^{**}This was the evaluator's best estimate of number of African people supported to improve their skills. Monitoring information was incomplete.

4.2 Progress towards target outcomes

The project aimed to create an active community of disabled participants in discussions. Implicitly, success required a significant number of voices sharing their experiences. The issue of *lurkers* or invisible participants (silent participants) is a well-known feature of social media communities, for example discussed in Gong et al⁹. Survey responses suggested the #SOS WhatsApp community was active i.e.

⁹ Gong, W., Lim, E. and Zhu, F. (2015) Characterizing Silent Users in Social Media Communities. Proceedings of the Ninth International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media, pp140-149.

85% of survey respondents indicated they contributed to WhatsApp discussions often or occasionally. This suggested only 15% of respondents would be classified as invisible participants. Of course, non-response to the survey invitation may well have been an indication of participants being invisible participants. If that were the case, a minimum of 46% of the #SOS WhatsApp community was still active¹⁰. In all likelihood, active participation was between 46% and 85%. A range of studies cited within Gong et al indicated invisible participants frequently made up 72-92% of all participants in various online communities i.e. only 8-28% might be active participants¹¹.

The interview sample was provided by the African Coordinator and the DWA Management Group, so the evaluators' anticipated the sample would have been some of the most prolific contributors to the WhatsApp group. However, none of the interviewees viewed themselves in this way. All suggested they were sometimes silent, unless they felt they could make a helpful contribution.

"I read a lot of the discussions, but got actively involved in just a few. This was because some discussions had a long thread already and I couldn't spend the time to read all the thread in order to be sure that I wasn't repeating opinions that were already on the thread."

#SOS participant

The #SOS WhatsApp community needed to be viewed as a safe place if disabled participants were to be expected to share their experiences with other members of the group. 96% of respondents felt their contributions were welcomed and they were personally valued by other members of the group¹². The same percentage of respondents found the #SOS group chat accessible and 92% found the chat inclusive¹³. Such high satisfaction rates suggested the #SOS community was viewed as a safe space.

"We did have some requirements that people kind of signed up to in terms of confidentiality and that it was a safe group for people to share and not a place for criticism and [...] disrespect for each other, but a safe place to share."

Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence. Available at https://ink.library.smu.edu.sg/sis_research/3107/. Accessed 6th April 2024

¹⁰ The minimum interaction rate of 46% was based on the 29 survey respondents indicating they had contributed to discussions being viewed as the only contributors to the #SOS WhatsApp thread.

¹¹ Ibid, p141

¹² Responses to question 4, annex C

¹³ Responses to question 5, annex C

Member of the DWA Management Group about rules of the #SOS group

Central to the project was improved potential for positively changing the lives of disabled people. The basis for such change lay in understanding participants' own situation and learning how others had prompted changes in their society when encountering comparable challenges.

82% of respondents indicated #SOS had helped them understand themselves or their role in society, while this increased to 89% suggesting they understood others or their role better¹⁴. It was clear from the comments of participants that #SOS discussions stimulated both improved understanding and a desire to create change.

"I discovered that my story relates with other stories in different parts of the world. It is an indication that the experience of disability stigma and discrimination is universal. But the drivers - economic, social and cultural of this experience may differ from society to society."

#SOS participant

"Being involved in the group provided information from other people in other countries who live with different disabling conditions than mine. Interacting with them challenges my opinions and attitude towards impairments as well as to ponder on how I advocate about disability."

#SOS participant

The Kirkpatrick model of training in organisations looks at four levels of change arising from the training¹⁵. This model identifies three levels of learning for individuals in that organisation and one at an organisational level, which in the context of this initiative could represent a disabled persons' organisation or society, potentially:

- Level 1 – Reaction – were the participants pleased with the programme?
- Level 2 – Learning – What did the participants learn in the programme?
- Level 3 – Behaviour – Did the participants change their behaviour based on what was learned?
- Level 4 – Results – Did the change in behaviour positively affect the organisation?

¹⁴ Responses to questions 6 and 7, annex C

¹⁵ Phillips, J.J. (2004) Handbook of Training Evaluation and Measurement Methods, Jaico, pp38-39

Two-thirds of respondents indicated they had come up with new ideas as a result of participation in #SOS¹⁶. In the Kirkpatrick model, this aligned with a level two response. These ideas were diverse and included:

- use of digital platforms to help disabled people's groups to gather and participate in development
- the importance of local context for international development programmes
- the importance of inclusivity
- the importance of gathering a wide range of experiences in finding solutions to problems faced by disabled people
- core problems faced by disabled people are universal and can be tackled globally
- greater understanding of sexual violence towards disabled people and the need to address
- development of new advocacy initiatives
- the use of stories in advocacy work.

As a consequence, 62% of respondents indicated #SOS involvement had led to changes for themselves or others, the highest level of change for individuals within the Kirkpatrick model¹⁷. *Empowerment* appeared to describe the change described by many, typically in the context of advocating for disabled people in their locality, nationally or even internationally.

The time between intervention and evaluation was relatively short, nevertheless some fourth level results were identified.

"Our organization trains blind people in the use of assistive technologies and software on-site. Because of the discussions on the group, we developed online courses that enable us reach trainees in other parts of Africa."

#SOS participant

"There was a story that was shared about a circle in Kenya of persons with disabilities and the other counties borrowed. And right now, as we speak, one of the counties was able to lobby for the same, and they are in the process of registering their circle."

#SOS participant

¹⁶ Responses to question 8, annex C

¹⁷ Responses to question 9, annex C

4.3 Legacy

Legacy was apparent at the level of individuals, their organisations and of the group itself.

A key theme amongst participants was that of improved understanding of other people's lived experience of their impairments / conditions. This enabled them to look at their own situation afresh.

"I came to appreciate myself more, and have gained more courage to face each day at a time. It's good to share with others for more mental growth."

#SOS participant

Another legacy theme at the individual level was of enhanced networks of disabled people, typically crossing national and impairment / condition boundaries.

The previous section indicated that some participants had taken ideas from the group and were using to promote development for disabled people in their own countries.

A key question was whether the WhatsApp group would persist beyond the lifetime of the project. The African Coordinator's view suggested legacy but with less momentum without a central coordinator.

"I'm seeing that three months past the project, we still have the group. Once in a while, people are posting very important stuff, but it is not as vibrant as when it was starting. But I can say that I am seeing that it has a future. It can still be sustained, even though not as actively as it has been."

African Coordinator

Participants tended to agree with that view. A common theme was the group would continue for as long as it continued to benefit participants. Most felt the loss of the African Coordinator would likely lead to a loss of momentum. The benefits of a central person to proactively introduce and moderate new topics of discussion were widely acknowledged.

An additional barrier to the continuation of the group was identified by several participants as the cost of mobile phone data in low-middle income countries. This was not a barrier during the period of funding, as small contributions to airtime were made to those that had need of such support to participate.

5. Conclusions, lessons learned and recommendations

5.1 Conclusions

The project largely achieved its outcomes i.e. establishment of a safe place where disabled people from across Africa and Wales could share their lived experiences for the benefit of other disabled people.

Participation had grown from disabled people drawn from four African countries plus Wales at the start of the project to 10 African countries plus Wales by the end. The findings indicated motivation to become participants tended to align with an objective of the project i.e. to learn from the lived experiences of other disabled people.

There was a high degree of participant engagement within the group i.e. a significantly lower percentage of silent participants than might have been expected, based on academic literature on the topic. This reinforced the finding that #SOS group was a safe place for disabled people.

There were high rates of respondents reporting improved understanding of themselves and others through participation in the project. This translated into a desire amongst participants to create change, either for themselves or others. Moreover, the findings suggested participants felt more empowered through their learning. The desire for change had translated into actual change reported by 62% of survey respondents.

A key objective was to generate a database of stories to support the continued education of disabled people across Wales and Africa. It was envisaged the stories would be used as tools in advocating for inclusive development. While not a formal project target agreed with the funder, DWA had established an internal target of 150 stories shared. This was exceeded by 10%.

Topics of discussion were defined by disabled people, reflecting their lived experience. Sub-groups formed around specific demographic groups.

The findings indicated significant learning by participants, both at a personal level and identified examples of translation of that learning into disabled people's organisations.

The findings identified project legacy, again at the individual and organisational levels. Continuation of the #SOS group, at least in the short term, was likely to be part of the project legacy. A caveat to this legacy was the group expecting to lose momentum when the African Coordinator leaves, given there was no obvious leader

to initiate / moderate discussion themes and proactively grow the #SOS participant numbers.

Output attainment presented a more mixed picture. Headline participant targets were not met in Africa nor Wales. This fed through to under-achievement in volunteering, education and skills outputs through direct participation. Potentially, indirect learning through cascade training into disabled people's organisations may have led to achievement of participation targets. While a plausible argument, this could not be verified nor quantified within the limits of this evaluation.

5.2 Lessons learned and recommendations

The conclusions indicated the discussions within the #SOS group were beneficial to participants and, in some instances, translated into advocacy within African nations. This suggested merit in the #SOS WhatsApp group continuing. A concern was frequency of posts would slow once and there was no coordinator.

Moreover, there was participant churn during the lifetime of the project (63 participants at the end but 74 in total throughout the year). Word of mouth was critical to participant recruitment, chiefly proactive recruitment by the African Coordinator. Unless recruitment continues, numbers of participants will likely reduce over time.

Recommendation 1: DWA and partners should seek a route to supporting a part-time African Coordinator for the #SOS group to give it the best chance of continuing its work.

While there was evidence of proactive recruitment of African participants, the findings did not identify similar levels of proactive efforts in recruiting Welsh participants. Potentially this reflected additional capacity funded by the project in Africa whereas contributions in Wales were provided as in-kind match funding by members of the DWA management group.

Recommendation 2: In designing future projects, DWA should recognise the need to fund adequate resources in Wales to support development work in Africa.

The original application had suggested additional capacity was to be provided through a social media intern. This had not happened by the end of the evaluation, potentially suggesting a lack of priority given to the Wales side of the project.

Recommendation 3: In delivering future projects, DWA should recognise the equal need to develop the Wales side of operations if it is to be of greatest benefit to Wales and Africa.

A large body of stories were collected through the #SOS project. There were some instances within the findings of stories empowering and inspiring some participants to create change. If more change is to be inspired by these stories, efforts will be needed to share key stories with a wider body of disabled people, and potentially non-disabled development organisations.

Recommendation 4: DWA should design and implement a proactive programme to share key stories from #SOS with relevant influencers to further its development objectives.

Annex A – Swansea University basic evaluation framework

The aim of SoS is to support collective support, learning and development around issues relating to disability.

The following questions are loosely based upon the work of Elizabeth Hanson in Linnaeus University, Sweden around the evaluation of participatory research (Hanson et al 2006). Participants in SoS will be invited to respond to the following 6 questions:

- Have you felt valued and has your contribution welcomed and if so, in what way?
- Has the SoS project been accessible and inclusive to everyone who wants to get involved or have some people been excluded and if so, in what way?
- Has being involved in the SoS project helped you better understand yourself and your role and if so, in what way?
- Has being involved in the SoS project helped you to better understand others and their role and if so, in what way?
- Has being involved in the SoS project resulted in you coming up with any new ideas and if so, what?
- Has being involved in the SoS project resulted in any changes and if so, what?

Reference

Hanson, E., Magnussen, L., Nolan, J. and Nolan, M. (2006) Developing a model of participatory research involving researchers, practitioners, older people and their family carers, *Journal of Research in Nursing*, 11(4): 325–342.

Annex B – Sample interview topic guide

#SOS – Topic Guide 2 – participants

Before starting:

- Introduce purpose of evaluation and how this interview will be used
- Gain explicit consent to proceed on following basis: confidential discussion, don't have to answer any questions and can terminate interview at any time, sometimes quote people anonymously in reports, permission to record.

Introduction

1. Do you remember how you heard about the Share Our Story (#SOS) project / WhatsApp group?
2. [If not already answered] Were you part of a community group or disabled people's organisation that promoted #SOS to you?
3. Why did you choose to get involved in the WhatsApp group?

The experience and difference made

4. What kind of discussions did you find most interesting or helpful? Why was that the case?
5. Did you get involved in these discussions or did you prefer to read other people's posts and not participate directly? Why was that the case?
6. What, if any, benefits did you get from the WhatsApp discussions?
7. Did you get involved in any other aspects of the #SOS project beyond the WhatsApp Group? If yes, what were these?

{Note to interviewer: The project targets noted events/activities would be run and education would lead to skills development. Explore whether events / activities / educational activities took place beyond the WhatsApp group.}

8. [If 'yes' to 6] What difference did each of these activities make for you?

Sustainability / Legacy

9. Has anything changed longer term for you or anyone you know as a result of being involved in the #SOS project?

[Prompt if necessary: Maybe your confidence has grown or perhaps you have started something new as a result of learning something from stories shared within the group?]

10. I know that Lucy Nkatha was a coordinator who posted regularly and started discussions on the WhatsApp group. To what extent do you believe the WhatsApp group would continue if Lucy or someone like her was not around?

Conclusion

11. Anything else you would like to say about #SOS project?

Annex C – Summary of participant survey responses

N.B. All comments are reproduced as written by respondents.

1. Please provide your first and last name (n=36)

2. In what country do you live?

(n=34)

Country	Number	Percentage
Canada ⁽¹⁾	1	2.9%
Central African Republic	1	2.9%
Ghana	1	2.9%
Kenya	13	38.2%
Nigeria	1	2.9%
South Africa	4	11.8%
Tanzania	3	8.8%
Wales	6	17.6%
Zambia	3	8.8%
No response	1	2.9%

Percentages do not sum to 100% due to rounding error

⁽¹⁾This response was by a member of the DWA Management Committee who originated from Ghana but currently resides in Canada. Their involvement included reaching contacts in north Ghana on behalf of #SOS.

3. Have you made any contributions to the WhatsApp discussions?

(n=34)

Answer	Number	Percentage
Yes – often	13	38.2%
Yes – occasionally	16	47.1%
No	1	2.9%
No – but I read other people's contributions	4	11.8%

4. To what extent do you agree with the following statements?

(n=25)

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Agree	Strongly agree
My contributions are welcomed by other members of the group	1 (4.0%)	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	12 (48.0%)	12 (48.0%)
I feel valued by other members of the group	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	1 (4.2%)	13 (54.2%)	10 (41.7%)

Not all percentages sum to 100% due to rounding error

Please comment further if you wish.

Despite the distance, I feel a strong sense of belonging to a community that can relate well with my personal disability story.
When comments or links are shared, there's a positive response from several members. The exchanges are always interesting and personal.
The interactions is very good between members in the group
Valued n respected
All contributions are welcome
I believe my contributions have generated discussion and debate.
There is always a healthy debate on the points that I and other members raise onthe group and people are always respectful and polite.
It's an excellent platform for people with disabilities
We need one day all members of the washApp group meet physically to know each better
The program is very good.
This deliberations are healthy and they enlighten the rights of differently abled persons of Wales & Africa. It should continue allover the world.
Through my contribution in discussions I'm able to appreciate myself. Through telling our stories I'm able to learn that I'm not alone in the disabilities fraternity. My art of telling stories has improved greatly through contribution from experts from Wales and other parts of the world. The program has assisted me to improve my advocacy skills. I'm able to participate in zoom meetings with ease compared to the time when I had not joined SOS.
The group was helpful and a leaning platform
I have had a great time in the group and have had learnings about disability rights and interventions in various countries

5. To what extent do you agree with these statements?

(n=27)

	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Agree	Strongly agree
I found the #SOS group chat accessible	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	1 (3.7%)	14 (51.9%)	12 (44.4%)
I found the #SOS group chat inclusive	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	2 (8.0%)	13 (52.0%)	10 (40.0%)

Please comment further if you wish.

We shared our stories mostly in textual or picture format. I think it would have been difficult for individuals with disabilities who have sight problems to independently participate.
Inclusion
No Discrimination
The group does not discriminat
Whilst i have not experienced problems, apart from my slowness of typing speed, I am aware that others have found it difficult to participate.
we are able to share useful information
The chat is educative and mind changer
There's a reasonable accommodation for all. The members had the freedom of choice in the topic to discuss. Topics were member driven.
That is true
Members we free n willing to participate

6. Has being involved in the #SOS project helped you better understand yourself and/or your role?

(n=27)

Response	Number	Percentage
Yes	22	81.5%
No	3	11.1%
Don't know	2	7.4%

If 'yes', in what way?

I discovered that my story relates with other stories in different parts of the world. It is an indication that the experience of disability stigma and discrimination is universal. But the drivers - economic, social and cultural of this experience may differ from society to society.
Through the topic discussion
To gage my knowledge with others in the group
It enable me to associate well with people
Participating in #SOS has enabled me to see some of the similarities and differences between experiencing disability in a high and low-income communities.
To know our challenge's that we are experiencing in our country and as i disabled person
Ir allowed me to learn more about people living with disability
By expressing my feelings better.
Being involved in the group provided information from other people in other countries who live with different disabling conditions than mine. Interacting with them challenges my opinions and attitude towards impairments as well as to ponder on how I advocate about disability.
It allows for introspection
i am able to share my story and find it easy to face my situation
Advocacy and inclusion
I learnt that I am deffently abled & specially made.
By knowing that I'm not the only disabled person in the world
Reading stories shared by other people like me have made me appreciate myself and motivated me to see the world differently
That there are others with challenges like me. The democratic space in our country gives us right and privileges. The other parts of the world face the same problems.
For discussion about together
Lean from each other across the bord

7. Has being involved in the #SOS project helped you better understand others and/or their role?

(n=27)

Response	Number	Percentage
Yes	24	88.9%
No	2	7.4%
Don't know	1	3.7%

If 'yes', in what way?

Whether a disabled person lives in a developed or developing countries, we are all disadvantage largely because of our disability. Many people shared stories of exclusion in jobs even when they have the right qualifications. Disability stigma and discrimination transcend both geographical and racial borders.
Reading about people's personal experiences of disability has helped to understand how resilient and creative many people are in overcoming some of the society barriers faced.
Self expression
Understand other people roles and interaction
I think i can understand the different perspectives of disabled people in Wales, a high income country, and much of Africa as a low income countries.
By experiencing disabilities not to ignore each other
It gave me a first hand insight as this gave them a platform to share their storie
For understanding other disabilities that I wasn't aware off.
Through the contributions and questions from the members, I have learnt a lot about their individual lives and how they respond to the challenges and opportunities that come their way. Apart from disability, I now understand the socio-cultural contexts that shape their views.
Knowing what others experience allows one to better understand disabilities
Learning experience from other countries on issues of Disabilities
i have gained more confidence
Stories of impact making
By able to chat with other deffently abled persons.
Different types of disability
When chatting with them only
Despite the disadvantages faced by many of us due to the physical and social environment, we are trudging on.
The laws of the land have created a clear roles and responsibilities for everyone. People living with disabilities and marriage life have unique challenges and sometimes the solutions come naturally. They sort themselves out as life shapes up.
Lots of stories help to built understanding on what other people across

8. Has being involved in the #SOS project resulted in you coming up with any new ideas?

(n=27)

Response	Number	Percentage
Yes	18	66.7%
No	6	22.2%
Don't know	3	11.1%

If 'yes', what were these ideas?

-the #SOS members have become part of my network and would spark awesome conversations anytime I meet anyone of them in-person. - It is possible to leverage on digital platforms to gather and empower groups that have been historically excluded in mainstream development. - Despite the similarities in our stories, local economic, social and cultural factors must be central in international disability programs.
Not sure if it's new ideas, but certainly new learnings which I reflect on in my own role.
Inclusive ideal and involvement
Leaning from other persons a cross the bord helps in improving n coming up with new ideas
It has confirmed my belief that, if we can overcome the communication and understanding difficulties, Global solidarity of disabled people is possible, because at their heart the problem they face are often very similar.
I worked on protection issues, but now i understand that sexual violence against PWD was not dealt with properly
As I read about the work of other members in pushing back the boundaries of discrimination in their countries, I gained insights that have helped me develop advocacy programmes like the commemoration of the World Braille Day on January 4 2024 at which we made new partnerships based on ideas learnt on the group.
Collection of impact stories
Having international friends
Many ideas in plenty. Self advocacy in day today day living. The art of telling stories has been enhanced by sos meetings and interactions. Personal engagements in marriage life has improved so much.

9. Has being involved in the #SOS project resulted in any changes for you or anyone else?

(n=26)

Answer	Number	Percentage
Yes	16	61.5%
No	6	23.1%
Don't know	4	15.4%

If 'yes', what were these changes?

I've become more empowered in using my disability story to inspire and empower both local and international audience
No challenge noted
My core belief remains the same, as does my desire to see the #SOS initiative continue and develop.
I have learn alot
I found the prooject empowering as it gave PWD a voice
Our organization trains blind people in the use of Assistive technologies and software on-site. Because of the discussions on the group, we developed online courses that enable us reach trainees in other parts of Africa.
Champion the rights of all PWDs
I have gained more confide ce and being able to end encourage people who just got their disability whom are not coping well
The strong wheel to create more awareness.
Realising my goal & working with other pwds.
Talking to some people who are disabled in my community
Understanding of the law of the land. Infact personally I acquired a totally different attitude towards myself and others. I'm able now to organize myself for some online meetings with other stakeholders compared to other times before.
Leaning new ideas from the team

Optional questions

10. To help us understand the mix of people involved in the #SOS group, please tell us how you identify yourself.

(n=27)

Response	Number	Percentage
Male	17	63.0%
Female	10	37.0%
Other (please specify)	0	0.0%

11. Please identify your disability / impairment / condition e.g. member of the Deaf community or wheelchair user

(n=25)

Physical disability
N/A
Hard of hearing. Working with the Deaf.
Person with Albinism
Nun of the above
Wheel chair user
Cerebral Palsy, wheelchair user with limited dexterity and communication impairments.
Physical
I am not a PWD but i set up an NGO in CAR to work with vulnerable groups. Most of PWDs beg on African streets. The NGO intends to build their capacities with local government so they can live in dignity.
Blind
Visually impaired person
Wheelchair user
Deaf/Hard of hearing
impairment
Albinism
Person with Albinism
Physically challenged
Spina bifida that courses physically disability , incontinence and use of two or one crutches
Deaf blind
Deaf blind
Wheelchair user
Caliper (leg brace) user
Physically challenged. Use crutches and orthopedic shoes.
Albinism
Person with physical disability

Annex D – List of organisations with which #SOS project engaged

Source: #SOS project monitoring system

Name of organisation	Country
Accesstech Innovation and research center(GTE) Limited	Nigeria
Action Pour Le Renforcement Des Capacites	Central African Republic
Albino Revolution Cultural Troupe	Tanzania
Azubi Africa Digital skills training program	Ghana
Black Albinism	Kenya
Blind S.A.	South Africa
Deafblind Zambia	Zambia
Deaflink Uganda	Uganda
Disability Arts Cymru	Wales
Disability Wales	Wales
Ghana Federation of Disability Organizations	Ghana
House of Hope	South Africa
Kakamega Deaf Association	Kenya
Kiengu Women Challenged to Challenge	Kenya
Lesotho National Federation Organizations of the Disabled	Lesotho
Meru County PWDs coordination structure	Kenya
MwembeKati Disability SHG	Kenya
National Council of and for PWDs	South Africa
North Imenti PWDs CBO	Kenya
Responsible Assistance	Wales
Visual World in Wales	Wales